Read This First: A Regime Theory of Joy

This article introduces the theory behind M-ZRT and should be read before the exercise catalog

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A Regime Theory of Joy
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A Regime Theory of Joy is a theory I developed independently that seeks to explain the mechanisms underlying joy. I argue that joy has so far largely escaped scientific investigation because of its elusive nature. In particular, it does not tolerate evaluation at entry.

Importantly, the second contribution of this work is the proposal of a mechanistically grounded task, specifically designed to induce joy.

In A Regime Theory of Joy, joy refers to a specific positive affective state characterized by a pleasant radiating sensation in the chest together with heightened olfactory sensitivity. This specific, intensive and abrupt phenomenology can in part rule out placebo or simple novelty effects.

Increased olfactory sensitivity may reflect greater engagement of the hippocampal system. If so, the hippocampus's role in contextual memory and associative processing could increase the richness and diversity of subjective experience, producing a wider range of positive "textures." In this state, colors may feel unusually vivid, almost like tasting candy, odors can evoke the feeling of entering a different world, and small shimmering objects may spontaneously elicit rich mental imagery.

This may explain why certain moments, especially during childhood, when access to this state is hypothesized to be easier, are remembered as unique.

A common idea is that the environment created the feeling. Instead, the environment may have acted as an amplifier of an already accessible brain configuration.

In principle, that would imply that spending an indefinite time in such a positive state may be theoretically possible.

Joy as a Problem of Causal Rigidity

According to the regime theory of joy, the primary bottleneck preventing joy is not a lack of reward or dopamine, but the increasing rigidity of learned causal chains. As we learn, the brain accumulates countless cause-and-effect relationships that organize perception and behavior. This accumulated rigidity is captured by the variable Z. Z progressively recruits a control regime specialized for prediction, optimization, and reliable action, but one that is incompatible with the regime of ease associated with joy.

Imagine a desk with a computer and a pencil. Each object recruits an enormous network of learned causal relationships, action tendencies, and predictions. A pencil is considered less valuable than a computer, so it is treated as more disposable. It is picked up in a particular way, used for writing while monitoring spelling, returned to its usual place, and often checked afterward to make sure it has not been misplaced.

These rules are also tied to object categorization: a pencil is "just a pencil," a computer is valuable because of its many functions, and each object automatically recruits its expected meaning and use.

As causal relationships accumulate, each selected action increasingly predicts the next one. Behavior becomes organized into long, self-maintaining chains in which each step recruits the following step. M-ZRT (Minimal Z-reduction task) introduces small discontinuities into these chains before they fully stabilize.

Why M-ZRT Targets Causal Chains

The goal of M-ZRT is to temporarily reduce the automatic recruitment of these learned causal relationships. Some tasks briefly perturb object categories, others interrupt familiar action sequences, and others leave sequences incomplete. Together, these small perturbations are proposed to reduce the rigidity of the underlying action structure, making the ease regime more likely to emerge.

Each ZRT exercise is effective only if the brain treats it as a minor, inconsequential perturbation. This is the central challenge of the method. It is also difficult because it runs counter to the principles of flow, a framework that is deeply ingrained. This makes the task psychologically counterintuitive.

If it is approached too seriously, the brain naturally re-engages comparison, evaluation, prediction, and monitoring. According to the theory, this reactivates the control regime that competes with the ease regime. At that point, the task no longer increases the probability of entering a joy-compatible state: It may even reduce it.

To illustrate this principle, consider the first exercise: **Alter Your Path**.

Normally, the player runs directly toward a destination. During the exercise *Alter Your Path*, the player introduces a small, purposeless deviation. They may change direction for a second or casually walk around an unimportant object before resuming their original route.

The primary activity is moving through the game world. Alter You Path is the disturbance.

Beginners often find Alter Your Path surprisingly difficult because it interrupts an ongoing action sequence. What is interesting is that many people find it easier to perform a complicated task than to introduce a small arbitrary disruption into an action that is already underway. Some people will have less difficulty solving a puzzle or meditating than walking for two seconds in a slightly different direction.

With experience, however, even more advanced exercises become easier.

Ideal Requirements

Outdoors, most exercises become significantly harder because everyday movement continuously recruits action planning.

- A third-person game
- An inventory with valuable items
- A peaceful town or safe area without combat or quests

Most RPGs and action RPGs (Diablo-like games) therefore provide it.

Beginner exercises

Here are a few exercises to start with. These are true beginner exercises, although many people will still find them surprisingly difficult at first.

At this stage, the goal is simply to understand how an exercise works.

> **Do not spam the exercises. It is important to leave periods of normal gameplay between them.**

Alter Your Path

Alter Your Path is a classic M-ZRT exercise. If a plan begins to feel established, alter your trajectory for a moment before resuming. The deviation should remain brief. To help treat it as a perturbation, you may sometimes think: “Not so fast”.

Visually, it produces a somewhat unusual sequence, which you can see here: https://youtu.be/kFQZ4VsY1sw?si=k9tMHf5Vc6FZByNz&t=69. It appears strange because the player is repeatedly interrupting the ongoing action (way too much for a beginner, actually, in this video).

One-Word Drift

Look at an object. Let one unrelated word pass through.

Chair → moon
Cursor → bird
The object and the word merely touch briefly in awareness. Because the word appears and disappears quickly, the exercise can be performed with almost no cognitive effort.

Another Possible Time

After seeing the current time, briefly imagine a different time appearing on the display instead

11:24 → 7:13

Cursor Passing

Let the cursor pass over an object, NPC, skill, menu option, or button without selecting it. The cursor passes over the target without selecting it.

Functional to Incidental

Briefly look at one visual detail that is currently irrelevant to the action you are performing.

Incomplete Caption

Looking at something, an internal description starts but remains unfinished.

Example:

"This is a..."

Conclusion

Once these exercises are understood and used naturally, they may already have opened a brief episode of joy, or perhaps even the ease regime.

You can find many other exercises that I have personally tested and validated: florianmorin.com/assets/pdf/Morin2026-Joy-Requires-Reduced-Action-Coupling.pdf

They can be applied in a wide variety of contexts, and some target action mechanisms more directly and more aggressively. This makes it possible to modulate the intensity of the intervention more rapidly, and, depending on the situation, the intensity of joy itself, if you got the ease regime opened.

Reference:
Morin, F. (2026). A Regime Theory of Joy: The Ease Regime as a Permissive Control Configuration. *SSRN,* http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6711318